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DEMONSTRATION

The First Degree Tracing Board in Modern English

Summary: Our Ritual is firmly rooted in the 18th and 19th centuries, and some of the words are no longer used in everyday conversation. This presentation used modern language to explain the First Degree Tracing Board.



First-Degree Tracing Board by Josiah Bowring
© Museum of Freemasonry, London

Notes: Requires a set of First Degree Working Tools on a tray for Narrator to carry. Requires First Degree Tracing Board (and pointer) to be set up in centre of Lodge so all present can see it.

[Worshipful Master & Narrator stand]

Worshipful Master: Brethren, our ritual informs that the Tracing Board was used by the Master to lay lines and draw designs. Operative Masons would have used his drawings to carry out their parts of the construction. Our Tracing Boards have evolved a similar purpose, in that they display many of the symbols and stories of Freemasonry, which we can use to build and develop ourselves.

[The Director of Ceremonies leads the Candidate to the North, where he can clearly see the Tracing Board; the Narrator stands beside the Tracing Board with pointer]

Narrator: On the Tracing Board we can see a number of symbols. We can moralise on them, by which we mean that we use them to represent our moral principles and values. This was a common form of instruction in earlier times, and by studying them in this way, we find that every character and emblem shown will help or guide us to understand the important principles of piety and virtue.

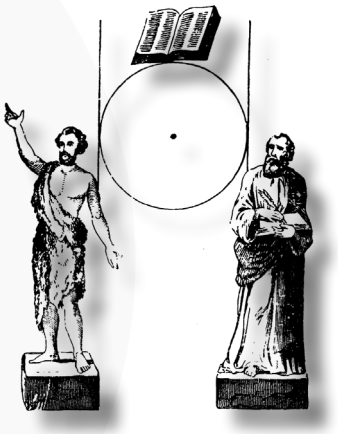
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[Narrator goes over to Candidate and leads him to stand in front of Worshipful Master's pedestal]

When you entered this Lodge as an Initiate, you were symbolically blind. Later your eyes were opened and you began your journey of Masonic learning towards truth. At the moment when the blessing of light was restored to you, the first things you saw were *the Volume of Sacred Law*, *the Compasses and the Square*. I have no doubt you remember their meanings. Taken together, they are known as **the Furniture of the Lodge**. The Volume of Sacred Law was given to us to rule and govern our faith. It is on this that we obligate our candidates. When united, the Compasses and Square are to regulate our lives and actions. The Compasses belong to the Grand Master in particular, and the Square to the whole Craft.

[Narrator takes Candidate back to the Tracing Board, and uses a pointer to indicate the features as they come up]

In all regularly formed Lodges there is **a point within a circle**. While you remain within its boundary, you cannot go astray. The circle is bound to its North and South by two parallel lines, one representing *Moses* and the other *Solomon*. In going around the circle, you will encounter both these lines and you are encouraged to follow the doctrines of the Volume of Sacred Law as closely as those two, so that you may reach that part of the circle where it rests. You will see that Jacob's Ladder is shown resting on the open book, and this might be interpreted as the starting point of your climb to the light that is revealed at its top.



From Masonic Manual, A. Mackey, a point within a circle (Moses and Solomon) Public domain



The Blazing Star © UGLE

This light comes from **the Blazing Star**, which is a symbol implying closeness to the Divine Presence. T*he Volume of Sacred Law* may be considered as the Spiritual Tracing Board of the Great Architect of the Universe, in which were laid down the Divine laws and moral plans. You are expected to follow these in all aspects of your life. Through faith in Divine providence, you will be able to take your first step on the ladder. You will note that there are many rungs, representing moral virtues. However, there are three main steps, on which we see symbols representing *Faith, Hope and Charity*. Faith in the Great Architect of the Universe, Hope in salvation, and to be in Charity with all men.

Your *Faith* will naturally create in you the *Hope* that you will be able to benefit from the Divine Promises contained in the Volume of Sacred Law to progress further up the ladder. *Charity*, in its fullest sense, embraces the other virtues. It is the brightest ornament for a Freemason. If he has charity in his heart, he will find himself able to reach the top of the ladder, where he will be near that wonderful light and the Ethereal Mansion, hidden behind the starry veil, represented here by seven stars. These will also remind you that no Lodge is perfect unless at least seven Brethren are present.

There are **three immovable Jewels** in the Lodge, *the Tracing Board*, *the Rough Ashlar* and *the Perfect Ashlar*. They are immobile and placed in full view, so that the Brethren can moralise on them. The Tracing Board has already been explained, so we now turn our attention to the Ashlars.

[The Director of Ceremonies collects the Working tools and follows Narrator and Candidate to Junior Warden's pedestal. Narrator then points out Rough Ashlar]

Once initiated, you might compare yourself to *the Rough Ashlar*, a stone that is taken from the quarry in its rough state. It is intended to use the stone in the structure, but without more work, it is not ready to be used.

[The Director of Ceremonies hands the Working Tools to the Narrator]

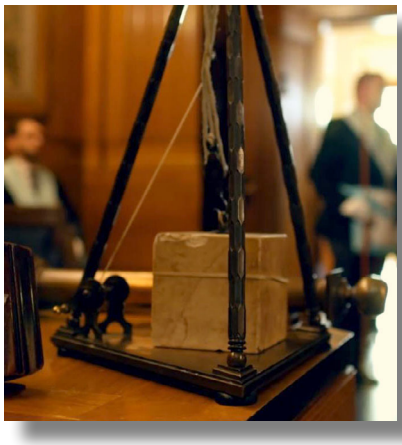
When **the Working Tools** were explained to you, you will remember that *the Twenty-Four Inch Gauge* was to measure our work *[demonstrates]*, *the Common Gavel* to knock off all superfluous knobs and excrescences *[demonstrates]* and *the Chisel* to further smooth and prepare the stone *[demonstrates]* and render it fit for the hands of the more expert workman. The alternative meanings of these symbols for Freemasons were also given to you. They should remind you of the proper use of your time, of the need to follow your conscience and of the value of education. We might reflect that, through the instruction and education provided by his parents, teachers and mentors, the character of a man develops to the point when he is ready to become a fit member of regularly organised society.



EAFs Working Tools (the Twenty-Four Inch Gauge, the Common Gavel and the Chisel) © UGLE

[Narrator returns the working Tools to the Director of Ceremonies, who replaces them in their position and resumes his seat. The Narrator leads the Candidate to Senior Warden's pedestal]

Your journey may therefore be described by reference to the process of turning *the Rough Ashlar* into *the Perfect Ashlar*, which is a square-cut stone, a perfectly formed building block, which should only be tested *by the Square and Compasses*. It may be said to represent a man in the autumn of his well-spent life, who will be tried by the Square of God's word and the Compasses of his own conscience. You will note that the Perfect Ashlar is shown below the Lewis, a tripod with a cord and a pulley, to which the Ashlar is attached by a cord fixed to it by a cramp, so it can be raised with little effort to the correct height for carefully positioning it in its intended place.



Lewis with the perfect Ashlar © UGLE

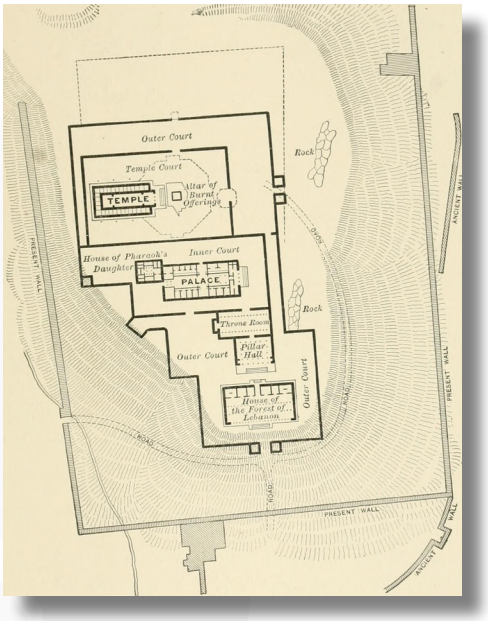
The Lewis represents the son of a Mason and reminds us of the interdependence of man and his parents, who looked after him and taught him when he was in his infancy. As they become aged, and more dependent on others, the man owes them support and protection.

[Narrator takes the Candidate to North-West corner of Lodge and both face North-East]

Let us now turn our attention to **the Lodge** itself. Our Lodges are said '*to stand on holy ground*', as they are dedicated before God. We deem them to be aligned on an East-West axis. Three reasons are given to explain this: -

- first, the sun, or the Glory of the Lord, rises in the East and sets in the West;
- second, it was believed that learning originated in the East and spread its positive influence westward;
- and third, the orientation of a Lodge is the same as that of the Tabernacle that Moses made as instructed by God.

The extent of the Lodge is described in vast terms: in length it reaches from the East to the West, in breadth from the North to the South; in depth from the surface of the earth to the centre; and even as high as the heavens. This reminds us of the universality of science. It also reminds us that a Mason's charity should know no limits, except those dictated by prudence.



Plan of Solomon's Temple. Public domain



Ionic, Doric and Corinthian columns representing Wisdom, Strength and Beauty. Public domain

We say that a Lodge is supported by **Three Great Pillars** known as *Wisdom, Strength and Beauty*. Wisdom that will assist us in all that we do, Strength that we may call on when we face difficulties, and Beauty of spirit that will show in our characters. These pillars are shown as columns of the Ionic, Doric and Corinthian orders of architecture. You will also observe these columns on the pedestals of the Master and the Wardens.

The universe may be considered to be the Temple of God. *Wisdom, Strength and Beauty* are found around His throne as pillars of His works: for His wisdom is infinite, His strength omnipotent and beauty shines through the whole of creation and is visible in its order and symmetries. He has created the heavens as a canopy and the earth is His footstool. He has crowned the heavens with stars. The sun and moon are messengers of his will, and all his law is concord. The three great pillars are emblematic of these divine attributes.

Next, let us consider **the Ornaments of the Lodge**. They are *the Mosaic pavement*, *the Blazing Star*, and *the Indented or Tessellated Border*. **The Mosaic pavement** is the beautiful flooring of the Lodge. Its chequered pattern of black and white represents the steps we take through life and its uncertainties.

[Narrator conducts the Candidate back to Tracing Board, walking on the chequered carpet, while continuing with the presentation]

Sometimes, we may walk across the sands of time in prosperity, but at other times we may stagger on the uneven paths of weakness, temptation or adversity. The emblem of the floor, which we see before our eyes, warns us against boasting of anything, and reminds us to walk uprightly with humility before God. No matter what our calling in life, we must keep in mind that, when death destroys all distinctions, we will all be of one level. As we cross *this mosaic carpet*, in our journey through life, may it remind us to act with reason, practise charity, maintain harmony and endeavour to live in unity and brotherly love.



The Mosaic Pavement © UGLE

[Narrator and Candidate arrive at the Tracing Board]

The Blazing Star, the Glory in the centre, has already been explained, but it also refers us to the sun, which sheds light on the earth. **The indented or tessellated border** refers us to the planets which, as they track their way around the sun, form a beautiful border around it, like this border in the Lodge.



The three movable Jewels - the Square, the Level and the Plumb-Rule. © UGLE

You have been told about the three immovable Jewels, and now we turn to **the three movable Jewels**. They are *the Square, the Level and the Plumb-Rule*. Among Speculative Masons, *the Square* teaches morality, *the Level* equality and *the Plumb-Rule* justness and uprightness of life. These Jewels are the emblems of the Worshipful Master, the Senior Warden and the Junior Warden. They are called movable Jewels because they are passed onto the new officers each year at the Installation ceremony.

In the corners of the Tracing Board we see *four tassels*. In some Lodges they are also displayed in the corners of the room or the corners of the carpet. *[Narrator indicates them, if they are displayed there]* The architect marks out the boundaries of the building with cords. At the corners, he knots them to a post, and leaves the frayed end loose. The tassels symbolise those frayed ends and are therefore associated with the boundaries of behaviour. They remind us of **the Four Cardinal Virtues**: *Temperance, Fortitude, Prudence and Justice*. *Temperance* gives us control over our emotions. We are expected to restrain our passions, by avoiding

excess, and embracing moderation. *Fortitude* lies midway between rashness and cowardice. It enables us to suffer pain or distress when necessary. *Prudence* teaches us to apply reason to our actions. As a result,we will form opinions wisely, and carefully decide on all matters that relate to our happiness. *Justice* should guide all our actions. It requires us to deal fairly with all men, without distinction. It is the cement that binds society together.



Grand Temple mosaic the Four Cardinal Virtues: Prudence, Temperance, Fortitude and Justice.
© UGLE

Worshipful Master: In the course of this presentation, many of the symbols and emblems to be found in the Lodge have been illustrated. During your progression through the Three Degrees, you will learn more about these and others. Let us end by reminding you that the three characteristics of a Freemason's heart are Virtue, Honour and Mercy; and may they ever be found in a Freemason's breast.

[The Director of Ceremonies takes the Candidate back to his seat and remains standing with his wand]

Brethren, it was usual to make a Charge at the end of each section of one of the Lectures. This is the charge from the sixth section of the First Lecture.

The Director of Ceremonies will direct your seated response. *'May Brotherly Love, Relief, and Truth in conjunction with Temperance, Fortitude, Prudence, and Justice distinguish Free and Accepted Masons till time shall be no more.'*

Director of Ceremonies: *The response is the Entered Apprentice's Sign three times, seated.*

To order, Brethren.

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Recommended use of Demonstrations

Demonstrations tend to be more theatrical, being designed as much to entertain as to educate. They come in a variety of forms:

- As a performance of a piece of ritual. For example, an 'Explanation of a Tracing Board' or a 'Demonstration Ceremony', sometimes supported by be an explanatory narration.
- As a play or playlet, performed for Masons and/or non-Masons. 'Talking Heads' is an example of a playlet designed to attract new members to the Royal Arch.
- As a precursor to a discussion, debate, or question and answer session.

The key to delivering a good demonstration is:

- The use of entertaining, informative and relevant material, which is well crafted and appropriate to the audience.
- Detailed prior planning, including:

ATTRACTING THE RIGHT AUDIENCE CHOICE OF VENUE AND TIMING ACCESS & PARKING

PRICING, TICKETING & SEATING MEETING, GREETING, REFRESHMENTS, MEALS & DRINKS

- Delivery by a dedicated team, or by a host Lodge or Chapter, supported by vibrant, experienced and knowledgeable actors, narrators or presenters, with the aid of appropriate props, lighting and audio-visual aids.
- Advertising and promotion by way of trailers, flyers and announcements in summonses, letters, emails, notice-boards and via social media

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